

some way to get user feedback and real-world data about upcoming builds of Windows before they are delivered to the general audience. For this purpose, they have the Windows Insider program.

Microsoft has always had some kind of beta program for people to test out its upcoming operating systems. Even with the very first release of Windows NT 3.1 Microsoft had beta versions of its OS available for select audiences.

Over time this audience has expanded significantly, to the point that now the only requirement to be a Windows beta tester is that you want to be one. Anyone can sign up to be a Windows Insider, and in Windows 10 you can turn switch on beta updates with a few clicks.

What Microsoft is doing with Windows 10 upgrades is similar to what has been happening with browsers for a while now. Firefox and Chrome both have multiple builds available. You have Firefox Nightly and Chrome Canary that both release unstable, minimally tested builds very regularly (nightly in Firefox's case). Then you have a better tested, but still quite frequently updated track: Firefox Aurora / Developer Edition and Chrome Developer. Then both browsers have a Beta track, and finally you have a release track. For enterprise users, both browsers also have editions that are updated less frequently.

The Windows 10 insider sign up process is quite simple. All they want to know is if you are really sure about using untested builds that might blow your computer to bits.

In Windows 10, an option is to join the Insider program, and then select the 'Fast' option for how often you want upgrades. Then you have the 'Slow' option, which still delivers beta builds but less frequently, after they are more tested. Then you have the regular release track that Windows 10 Home users are locked into, unless they want to get even faster updates in the Insider track.

Windows 10 Pro and Enterprise users can use an option to defer updates, which keeps security updates coming, but delays Windows 10 upgrades a few months till they have already been tested by Insiders, and regular customers who can't or haven't delayed upgrades. 